



24/7 Live

62°

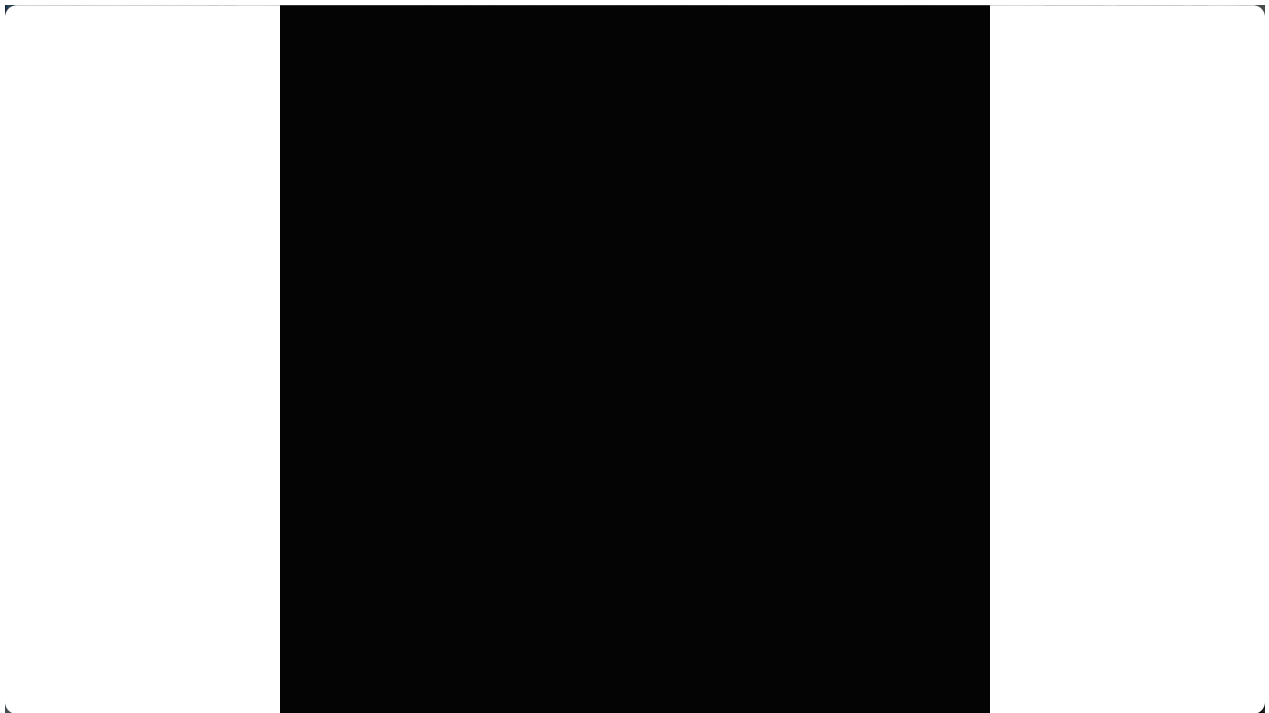
IMMIGRATION

## Protest blocks downtown traffic after 3 arrested in Lawndale as part of operation 'Midway Blitz'

ABC News rode along with ICE agents as they made arrests on the West Side Tuesday.

By [Evelyn Holmes](#), [Craig Wall](#), and [Tre Ward](#) 

Tuesday, September 9, 2025



A large protest against immigration enforcement blocked traffic in downtown Chicago for hours on Tuesday evening.

CHICAGO (WLS) -- A large protest against immigration enforcement blocked traffic in downtown Chicago for hours on Tuesday evening.

"We must organize. We must stay in the streets and keep each other safe!" one protester said.

[ABC7 Chicago is now streaming 24/7. Click here to watch](#)

The Coalition Against the Trump Agenda and the Illinois Coalition for Immigrant and Refugee Rights hosted a rally at Congress Plaza Garden on Tuesday evening before marching in the streets to make their voices heard.

"We are going to keep fighting against the escalated ICE raids and attacks against our communities. Trump says that it's going to be war in Chicago, but I believe in the people's power and the resistance here in strong," said Rania Salem with the U.S. Palestinian Community Network.

About 200 demonstrators marched on Michigan Avenue around 6 p.m.

"We will be out on these streets. So, get ready. Buy you some new shoes!" one demonstrator said.

**READ MORE** | [Chicago federal intervention: Tracking surge in immigration enforcement operations](#) | [Live updates](#)

The group later returned to the plaza, where the rally resumed. Organizers told ABC7 that they were committed to keeping the demonstration peaceful.

"We're going to talk about how we're meeting the moment, right now," another demonstrator said.

## ABC News gets inside look at immigration arrests





ABC News Chief Justice Correspondent Pierre Thomas along with ICE agents as they made arrests on the West Side on Tuesday.

The protest came after federal agents descended on Chicago's Lawndale neighborhood as part of [operation "Midway Blitz"](#) on Tuesday.

Agents from Immigration and Customs Enforcement along with Alcohol, Tobacco, and Firearms agents arrested three men they say are suspected gang members. ABC7 blurred their faces because we do not know whether they have been charged.

ABC News Chief Justice Correspondent Pierre Thomas spoke with the head of the ICE operation, which the Department of Homeland Security says is targeting criminal offenders who are in the U.S. illegally.

"We're talking anywhere from the most egregious child sex offender to, homicide, burglary, assault, domestic violence, it runs the gamut. It's everybody that's committed crime, but the ones we're going to primarily focus on, the ones that we want to get off the streets are going to be our heinous criminals," Marco Charles, acting director of ICE Enforcement and Removal Operations told ABC News.

Thomas rode along with ICE agents as they made arrests on the West Side on Tuesday.

ATF Special Agent in Charge Jonathan Maniff said they are investigating possible gun trafficking by the Tren de Aragua gang. That was the focus of Tuesday's arrests in Chicago, Thomas told ABC7.

"This investigation started through our crime gun intelligence center with our 15 partner agencies that include ICE. And during this operation, we identified 30 TDA suspected gang members that were selling firearms in the Chicagoland area," Maniff said.

Thomas told ABC7 the federal agents did not locate the main person they were looking to take into custody on Tuesday. Thomas said investigators told him that person has sold undercover agents about 14 guns, and they believe they can tie those guns to shootings, carjackings and even homicides.

The arrest comes as DHS Assistant Secretary Tricia McLaughlin says, "DHS is

launching Operation Midway Blitz in honor of Katie Abraham who was killed in Illinois by a criminal illegal alien who should have never been in our country."

**SEE ALSO** | [Katie Abraham's father speaks out on DHS' operation 'Midway Blitz' in Chicago area](#)

The operation, which began was announced Monday, is part of a 30-day federal immigration enforcement surge in the Chicago area.

Thomas also told ABC7 that the agents he spoke with on Tuesday are very proud of the work they are doing. He asked them why they wear face coverings, at times, while taking people into custody, and one agent told him they have concerns about security and doxing.

In the ride-along footage, ABC7 blurred the faces of the agents, as many of them work undercover. ABC7 also blurred the faces of those arrested, as it is unclear if they are facing any charges.

## Gov. Pritzker, local leaders push back on immigration crackdown



Federal agents descended on Chicago's Lawndale neighborhood as part of operation "Midway Blitz."

Meanwhile, Illinois Gov. JB Pritzker met with activists who support immigrants on Tuesday, talking about strategies for how best to address the immigration

enforcement surge. Several community groups are also planning resistance strategies.

Pritzker said there is a lot of fear out there about what the Immigration and Customs Enforcement operation will actually turn into. And as President Donald Trump continues to talk about cleaning up Democrat-run cities, Pritzker made it clear, once again, that he has no plans to ask for federal help like the National Guard.

Pritzker met with a group leaders representing numerous advocacy groups who are trying to inform people of their rights and help them stay safe as they wait for the ICE raids to ramp up.

"We're going to talk about how we're meeting the moment right now," one woman who attended the meeting said. "What does that actually look like? What does the various programs look like?"

The governor offered some encouragement.

"The reason that Tom Homan, the reason that Donald Trump, the reason that so many people, you know, are upset and want to attack Chicago is because we're winning," Pritzker said. "Even though this is a terrible moment, we are winning here, We are, even if there are still people who are being taken and still there are attacks in our communities."

It comes as various community groups continue to criticize operation "Midway Blitz," the name given to the stepped-up immigration enforcement effort that the Trump administration has said will target the "worst of the worst" criminals who are not in the country legally.

After touring the National Museum of Mexican Art, the governor admitted that the state is being kept in the dark about ICE activity. Pritzker said he is not sure when the ICE operation will ramp up, but he says they have about 100 vehicles at the ready.

"Here's what we do know: ICE is somewhere on the ground here. They already have been effectuating their plans. We have not seen the bulk of those ICE agents yet in communities, but we have seen some, and we know that they are gathering steam," Pritzker said.

The White House border czar, Tom Homan, defended the operation that is expected to



---

look similar to what happened in Los Angeles.

**RELATED** | [Controversial ICE tactics cleared by Supreme Court; advocates worry they may be deployed in Chicago](#)

"We're sending a message to the whole world; there are consequences for violating our laws. You're asking me to tell ICE, 'Don't enforce the law.' Should DEA enforce their laws? Should FBI enforce their laws? Should ATF enforce their laws? ICE is going to enforce the laws. That's what President Trump got elected for and what we're doing," Homan said.

Faith leaders on the West Side are calling this "Resistance Tuesday." They gathered in Pilsen, where community members are getting ready to celebrate Mexican Independence Day this weekend

"When it comes to putting our sons and daughters in the back of unmarked vans by agents that do not want to be known, accountable by anybody, we have to say 'No,'" said Rev. Joe Morrow with 4th Presbyterian Church.

Organized by the Leaders' Network, the collection of prominent clergy came together on Tuesday, united by their opposition to any federal takeover of Chicago.

"It's so important that this is an interfaith gathering that Christians, Jews and Muslims are coming together to say that we're going to fight for Chicago," said Leaders' Network President David Cherry.

Their message is that Chicago needs investment, not occupation.

"So, while he is championing that there's a need for the military to solve this problem, we believe in resources," said New Landmark Baptist Church Pastor Cy Fields.

Many say Trump is using crime in predominately Black and Brown communities as an excuse to occupy the city.

"We resist what he is doing," said Greater Union Baptist Church Pastor Dr. Walter McCray. "We stand flat footed, morally and spiritually and resist what he is doing. We are not afraid. We can control our community if we have the resources, the resources

to hire 10K."

Administration officials say their actions are necessary to apprehend undocumented people, who they say are being given refuge in sanctuary cities, adding that they have seen a reduction in crime in Washington, D.C. after the National Guard was called in to help.

If National Guard troops were deployed in Chicago, military experts say, they would likely be used to guard federal buildings.

The troops are trained for military combat, not policing crime and cannot be dispatched by 9-1-1 to crime scenes.

"It's looking for an excuse to have further crackdowns on valid protests and to provoke attack, and that's my deepest concern, that these troops are coming here to provoke, not to protect," said Oak Park Temple Rabbi Max Weiss.

*ABC News contributed to this report.*

[Report a correction or typo](#)

Copyright © 2025 WLS-TV. All Rights Reserved.

**Related Topics**

- POLITICSCHICAGOLOOPIMMIGRATIONRALLYDONALD TRUMP
- PRESIDENT DONALD TRUMPICEJB PRITZKERBRANDON JOHNSON
- STATE POLITICSWASHINGTON POLITICSPROTESTTRAFFIC



**Topics**

- Home
- Weather
- Traffic



[Watch](#)

[Photos](#)

[Apps](#)

## Regions

[Chicago & Suburban Cook Co.](#)

[North Suburbs](#)

[West Suburbs](#)

[South Suburbs](#)

[NW Indiana](#)

## More Content

[Local News](#)

[U.S. & World](#)

[I-Team](#)

[Politics](#)

[Entertainment](#)

[Consumer & Business](#)

## Company

[About ABC7 Chicago](#)

[ABC7 Newsteam Bios](#)

[Community Journalism](#)

[TV Listings](#)

[ABC7 Jobs - Internships](#)

[Contests, Promotions & Rules](#)

[Community](#)



